

Real-world (a cold interview on your own project)

— Hints

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Only 2 hints — work through them in order, and don't jump ahead until you've genuinely tried. Each hint has 3 depth levels: **Basic** (the plain answer a nervous first-timer would give), **Intermediate** (a properly structured senior-level answer, using this document's own Four-Depth Format), **Advanced** (defending the design under direct challenge, or walking through a project cold with zero warm-up). Read Basic first even if you're confident — it's the fastest way to see exactly what each deeper level adds.

- [Hint 1 — The idea, and the four beats](#)
- [Hint 2 — The plan, and almost the whole walkthrough](#)

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Hint 1 — The idea, and the four beats

Basic Version

For this hint, use Project 4 (ContentForge: Supervisor-Led Team) as the example, even if you'd normally pick your own — the idea transfers directly to whichever project you actually walk through.

An interviewer who's never seen your project doesn't want a tour of every file. They want the shape of the thing: what problem it solves, what the pieces are, and why you built it that way instead of some other way. Before answering anything, decide on the *order* you'll present things in — problem, then design, then one interesting decision, then what you'd change. Don't start by describing code.

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Intermediate Version

A project walkthrough is a different skill than answering a factual question — it's **narrative construction under the assumption of zero shared context**. The interviewer has never seen your README, your CURRICULUM.md, or your code. Every acronym or internal name (Doc11, "supervisor pattern") needs either a one-clause explanation or needs to be avoided in favor of a plain description.

Use Project 4 (ContentForge) as this hint's working example. Structure it the way this document's own Four-Depth Format structures any answer — start at the 30-second claim ("what it does, for whom"), then let it rise into Normal depth: **problem** → **architecture at a glance** → **one decision worth defending** → **one honest limitation**. Interviewers specifically listen for whether you can identify your own project's weakest point unprompted — volunteering it (briefly, not apologetically) is a stronger signal than waiting to be caught.

Draft your own four-part outline (for any project of your choice) before Hint 2.

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Advanced Version

Two curveballs happen often in real project-walkthrough interviews, and both are worth rehearsing separately from the plain four-beat walkthrough:

Curveball 1 — the direct challenge. Right after you name "one decision worth defending," a skeptical interviewer pushes back with a simpler alternative: *"Why not just use a fixed pipeline with one retry loop instead of a full supervisor — isn't the supervisor added complexity for one edge case?"* The wrong move is either caving instantly ("yeah, maybe that would've been simpler") or getting defensive and re-explaining the same decision louder. The right move names the *specific requirement* the simpler alternative can't meet, concedes the real cost of your choice honestly, and — if the challenge has a genuine point — says so.

Curveball 2 — the cold project switch. Mid-conversation, the interviewer says: *"Interesting — tell me about a different project instead, one where something went wrong."* There's no prep time for this. The skill is having the same four-beat shape (problem → architecture → decision → limitation) memorized as a *reusable structure*, not memorized *per project* — so you can slot any project into it on the spot, including one you didn't expect to discuss.

The real design question isn't "do I know my project well" — it's "can I defend one real decision under a direct, reasonable challenge, and can I produce the same four-beat shape for a project I didn't prepare tonight?"

Try both before Hint 2: defend the supervisor-vs-fixed-pipeline decision under pushback, and outline a different project's four beats from memory, cold.

Difference between Basic, Intermediate, and Advanced: Basic and Intermediate both assume a cooperative interviewer who lets you finish your prepared walkthrough. Advanced assumes the two things that actually happen in a strong interview: someone pokes at your one defended decision with a real alternative, and someone asks about a project you didn't rehearse tonight — both test whether the four-beat structure is a genuine habit or a script for exactly one project.

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Hint 2 — The plan, and almost the whole walkthrough

Basic Version

Four things to cover, roughly in this order, using Project 4 as the example:

problem: "content teams need articles researched, drafted, and fact-checked without one person doing all three badly"

shape: "one supervisor agent decides what happens next; specialist agents do research, writing, and fact-checking; supervisor routes between them based on what's done so far"

one decision: "I used a supervisor instead of a fixed pipeline, because the fact-checker sometimes needs to send work BACK to the writer – a fixed pipeline can't loop, a supervisor can decide that"

one limitation: "right now if the fact-checker rejects something three times in a row, it can loop forever – I'd add a max-retry count with more time"

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Intermediate Version

The same plan, at the level you'd deliver it live:

problem: state the user-facing need, not the technical implementation

shape: name the pattern (Doc11's supervisor pattern), name the agents,
and connect the pattern choice to a SPECIFIC requirement
("needs to loop back" -> "supervisor can route backward, a fixed
pipeline can't")

one decision: pick something with a real trade-off – e.g. "why a
supervisor and not a fixed sequential pipeline" – and be
ready to say what you gave up (a supervisor is harder to
reason about statically than a fixed pipeline)

one limitation: name a genuine gap (unbounded retry loop, no cost cap on
re-drafts) and the specific fix you'd add, not just "it's
not perfect"

Notice the "one decision" section explicitly includes what you *gave up* — a decision defended without acknowledging its cost sounds like marketing, not engineering judgment.

Fill this in for your own project, say it out loud once, then move to the Advanced Version below.

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Advanced Version

The plan for defending the decision under direct challenge:

your decision, as stated: "supervisor instead of a fixed pipeline, because fact-check failures need to route backward"

interviewer challenge: "isn't that added complexity for one edge case? a fixed pipeline with a single retry loop around the fact-check step would handle that too, and it's simpler to reason about."

your move:

concede what's true: a single conditional retry loop IS simpler, and for exactly one back-edge, it might genuinely be enough

name the specific thing it stops covering:

a fixed retry loop only knows how to go back to ONE fixed place; if a future specialist (e.g. an SEO-check step) also needs to be able to send work backward, the fixed pipeline needs a new hard-coded loop for every new case – the supervisor already generalizes to that without new wiring

name what you gave up honestly:

harder to statically trace than either option, more moving parts to test

land on the actual call:

for the CURRENT scope, a fixed retry loop might have been enough – the supervisor was a bet on the pipeline growing more conditional paths, which is a judgment call, not an obvious win

And the plan for the cold project-switch, as a reusable shape (not memorized per project):

for ANY project, on demand:

problem -> one sentence, user-facing, no jargon

shape -> pattern name + agents/parts + why that pattern fit

one decision -> something debatable, plus what you gave up

one limitation -> a real gap, plus the fix you'd add

practice this shape against a SECOND project you didn't plan to discuss tonight, cold, before checking the Solution

[Back to the exercise](#) · [Hint 1](#) · [Hint 2](#) · [Solution](#)

Full solution: [Show me the solution](#)